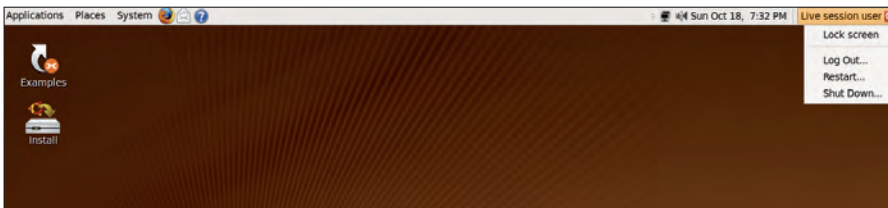


Forget the Dock

If you're a Mac user, or a Windows user who loves fancy docks, stop it. They're more pretty than useful. On Macs, get your hands on DragThing; on Windows, use Windows

Touch too

Yes, the science of user interfaces applies to touch UIs as well. Some concessions can be made because the finger is easier to move than a mouse, but Fitts's law still keeps things sane

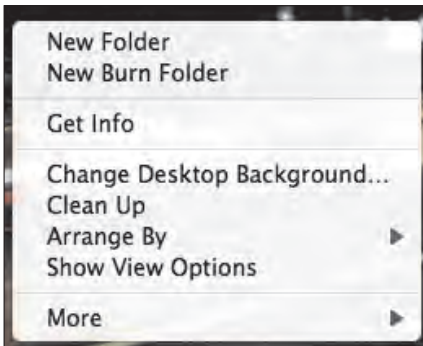


Ubuntu tries to do the top bar thing like the Mac, but putting the "log off" button in such an important position is just silly

The case of the contextual menu

You can't really appreciate the importance of a right-click (contextual) menu until you've used a one-button Mac mouse. Not that Macs don't have the contextual menus – the pre-Mighty mice just don't have a right mouse button. But that's not the issue here.

We have contextual menus because of the 'keep the targets close to the cursor' bit of Fitts's Law – the menu appears wherever you right-click, and the menu item you want is a short distance away. The contextual



Apple tries to keep the length of its context menus in check. Sometimes, they're even successful

menus we have today aren't the best solutions, though: they're vertical, so if the item you want is at the bottom, you have to move the cursor a longer distance than if it were at the top.

The best way to create contextual menus that embody all that Fitts would approve of is the pie menu – all the menu items arranged in a circle—though very few programs use one. There are two good



Pie menus are fine for a few menu items, but they can get messy for bigger menus



You can save screen space by making the dock small, but then you have these big icons jumping up at you

things about pie-shaped menus: first, all the menu items are the same distance from your cursor, and second, you don't need to remember the names of the items – eventually, you'll be able to access them just through motor memory.

The case of the Mac Dock

We seem to be a bit fixated on the Mac, don't we? The Dock is one of the 'likeable' things that Steve Jobs goes on about, and makes for some really nice-looking promotional material. But is it Fitts-y good? Let's look at what we have, here: it's on the bottom edge, so that's nice. It's got big, shiny targets; that's nice too. What isn't nice, though, is that those big targets take up a lot of vertical space – on wide

screens, which don't give us much vertical space anyway. You can work around this by making the dock really tiny, but turning on magnification so the icons get bigger when you approach them.

To add to the annoyances of the dock, it gives you moving targets. As you open more programs, the dock resizes itself, taking the Trash icon with it. So if, at any point, you thought you'd commit the Trash's location to your motor memory, tough luck.

And yet, this happened:

The case of the Windows 7 taskbar

As Microsoft's answer to the Dock, the Windows 7 taskbar inherits much of its silliness – the unnecessary height (there really wasn't much wrong with the original short-but-wide taskbar, really) and the confusion between open applications and regular old shortcuts, to name a couple. On the other hand, it does bring some useful targets closer to the mouse cursor by way of jump lists – you can access recent folders, web pages, and so on just by right-clicking on the program's icon. UI design-wise, then, there's nothing to jump about, but there's nothing overly awful here, either.

Moving on, then.

The case of the 3D desktops

This is another thing we must blame Mac OS X for. Features like Exposé brought to us the idea that windows don't need to be drawings on a screen – they can be real objects that can be tossed around a

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